

Aztec foundations

The Aztecs may have begun their wanderings in northern Mexico around 1200. For the next 100 years they eked out a miserable existence as mercenaries or barely tolerated squatters, their plight not aided by their reputation as cruel warriors. Frequently, they had to flee after committing violent acts, at times involving human sacrifice; indeed, their flight to Tenochtitlan was prompted by one such incident. The Aztecs had asked their host, the lord of Culhuacán, whether he would give his daughter as a bride for their chief. He agreed, believing she would be greatly honored as queen; however, to his horror they killed and flayed her as a sacrifice to their deity Xipe Totec. Driven out by the lord and his soldiers, the Aztecs fled southward toward the future site of Tenochtitlan.

Although the soil around Lake Texcoco, on which the island of Tenochtitlan was situated, was marshy and there was very little timber available, the capital was easily defensible and the Aztecs used it to consolidate their position. Initially shielded by a treaty with the Tepanec ruler Tezozomoc, who dominated the Valley of Mexico from 1371 to 1426, the Aztecs went on to form a Triple Alliance with the cities of Texcoco and Tlacopan in 1428—a union that kick-started a period of imperial expansion.

Aztec expansion

In the early days, Aztec society had little formal hierarchy. It was based around communities (*calpulli*), that owned land in common and whose chiefs, together with priests, ruled on important decisions. In 1376, the Aztecs chose for the first time an overall leader (*tlatoani*), who came to serve as war leader, judge, and administrator for the burgeoning empire. Under Itzcoatl (1427–1440), Montezuma I (1440–1469), Axayacatl (1469–1481), and Ahuizotl (1486–1503) Aztec armies subdued their neighbors in the Valley of Mexico and then spread outward, reaching Oaxaca, Veracruz, and to the edges of land controlled by the Mayan people in the east of modern-day Mexico and Guatemala.

As the Aztec Empire expanded, society was transformed. A warrior elite emerged, while at the bottom of society bondsmen (*mayeques*), who owned no land, were bound by labor service to their lords. The militaristic nature of Aztec society was accentuated by an education system in which all males received military training (in separate schools for nobles and commoners). This reinforced the warrior ethos and gave the Aztecs an incalculable advantage over neighboring tribes in Mexico.

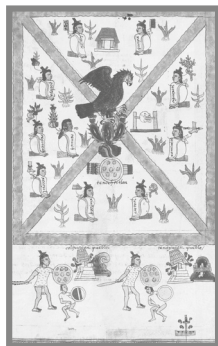
The imperial system

Tenochtitlan was adorned by many temples to the gods of the Aztec pantheon. Each god had their own temple, with the Templo Mayor having twin shrines dedicated to Huitzilopochtli and Tlaloc, the rain god. At these temples a stream of human victims was sacrificed—up to 80,000 at the rededication of the Templo Mayor in 1487—by burning alive, decapitation, or cutting open the chest and removing the heart.

Many of the Aztec battles were “flower wars”: ritual affairs in which opponents were captured (rather than killed) and sacrificed to placate the Aztec gods, who were believed to need blood to sustain them and keep the sun moving across the sky.

Tenochtitlan also exacted tribute from its subjects. Although there was very little in the way of an organized government bureaucracy, there were tax collectors, who crisscrossed the 38 provinces of the Aztec Empire and levied tribute, which included 7,000 tons of maize, 4,000 tons of beans, and hundreds of thousands of cotton

blankets each year. The empire depended on this tribute to reward the nobility and »



The founding of Tenochtitlan is illustrated in the *Codex Mendoza*: a record of Aztec history and culture created c. 1540 by an Aztec artist for presentation to Charles V of Spain.